OBITUARY: RAGHU RAI (1942-2026)

SOUL SEER

Raghu Rai leaves behind a visual memory of India—its grief and its grace, its sacred and its scars. At once graphic and lyrical, he placed ordinary folk at the heart of the nation's story

By **BANDEEP SINGH**

In the passing of Raghu Rai, 83, on April 26, India lost not merely an extraordinary lensman, but a worshipper of the spirit of India—one through whose gaze the world glimpsed this land's luminous, emotional core. His lens drew in not just reflected light, but the ancient light of our culture, drenching the subject with an Indianness that was at once deeply intimate yet entirely universal.

Just as a temple draws sanctity not from stone but through what it stirs inside you, Raghu Rai's India is one where, amid all its paradoxes, its chaos and its milling multitudes, there lies a glow of quiet grace—an inherent ease of being that is its silent celebration, its sandalwood paste. With Rai gone, India has lost its most faithful visual chronicler, one who consecrated six decades of this country's visual history through his lens.

To reduce Rai to the grammar of accolades is to diminish him. Yes, he was the first Indian admitted to Magnum Photos, nominated by the legend Henri Cartier-Bresson himself. Yes, he carried the Padma Shri, France's Officier des Arts et des Lettres, and was feted by publications like *Time*, *Life*, *National Geographic* et al. But these are decorations placed upon a life, not the life itself. The life was something more austere, more radical: a daily act of seeking, a rigour that led him to go out into the field and, within its tumult and torpor, find the image that would make the fleeting permanent.

Those who worked alongside him at INDIA TODAY, where he served as its celebrated photo editor through the 1980s, will remember the ferocity with which he fought for his images. He resisted the hegemony of words, calling them "a wall of bricks" that needed "*khirkiyan*", visual windows that let it breathe. "Without these," he would say, "the reader is left in a sealed room, breathing recycled air." He fought for double spreads, the uncropped photo, the image given room enough to breathe and be meaningful. He won more often than editors would care to admit, because you could not argue once you had seen how his images could elevate a space.

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And what those photographs could do with darkness was something else entirely. Rai's black-and-white work operated in a tonal and emotional range that few Indian photographers of his generation—or since—have matched. His prints were marked with deep, architectural blacks: shadows that were not an absence but an intensification, a visual counterweight that lent the lit areas an almost unbearable luminosity. This was not merely the gift of a good eye. It was darkroom chemistry pursued with the obsession of an alchemist. In his silver prints, Rai extracted the minutest detail from his negatives, at times pushing the film until the grain itself became expressive. A study of the blacks in a Raghu Rai print reveals a man who understood light the way a musician understands silence. The woman praying against the backdrop of Jama Masjid under a stormy sky. The lone widow in stark contrast to a resplendent Durga idol at a Kolkata ghat. Two figures—contrasting in age and wealth status—crossing each other against a wall in Delhi's Daryaganj. More than photographs, they are raga-like compositions, shaped by light, then frozen within it.

And he was, in the truest sense, a man in thrall to music. To see him photograph a Hindustani classical concert was to witness two performances simultaneously. While the maestro on stage surrendered to the raga, Rai submitted to its unfolding—his body swaying in ecstasy with an involuntary Wah! You may not see that exclamation, but it is the most prominent note running through his charged, atmospheric

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